1. What you're doing (30 seconds) "I'm building a model that reads social media posts and figures out which mental health state someone might be showing — depression, anxiety, PTSD, or stress — instead of just 'depressed or not depressed,' which is what most existing work does."

2. Why it's not already been done (this is the impressive part) "Existing papers do one of two things: either they classify text and show which words the model used, but never check if those words actually make clinical sense — or they check against clinical scales like PHQ-9, but only on structured clinical data, not real social media posts. Nobody's combined both — actually checking whether the model's reasoning matches real clinical symptoms, on real social media text."

3. What you'll actually build "I'll train a classifier on labeled Reddit posts, use SHAP to see which words the model relies on for each category, then build a scoring system that checks those words against official symptom checklists doctors use — PHQ-9 for depression, GAD-7 for anxiety. If the model is using words like 'hopeless' and 'can't sleep,' that's clinically valid. If it's just picking up slang or subreddit patterns, that's a red flag — and I'll show that in the results."

4. Why this matters (the impact line) "This isn't just another accuracy score. It's checking whether these models can actually be trusted, or whether they're cheating by picking up patterns that have nothing to do with mental health. That's the real problem stopping these tools from being usable in practice."

5. What you're NOT doing (shows maturity, not gaps) "I'm not building anything that diagnoses individuals or flags real people — that's unethical and not what this is for. It's a research and validation study, using existing public, anonymized data only."

6. Close with a question, not a statement "I've scoped this to fit in 6-8 weeks using a dataset that's already public and labeled. I wanted your take before I lock it in — does this direction make sense to you, or is there an angle you'd push me toward?"